

Research Briefing

24 April 2026

Number 10521

By Philip Loft

Israel/US-Iran conflict 2026: Background and UK response

Summary and background	2
1 United States and Israeli strikes	4
1.1 What reasons did the US give for the strikes?	5
1.2 Israeli Government statements	7
1.3 What have the US and Israel targeted in Iran?	7
2 Counter-strikes and attacks by Iran and its allies	8
2.1 Iranian counter-strikes and Strait of Hormuz	9
2.2 Actions of Iran-backed armed groups	10
3 Situation in Iran and new leader	14
3.1 Leadership and new Supreme Leader	15
3.2 Iranian society	16
4 UK response to the 2026 conflict	17
4.1 UK backs UN Security Council resolution	17
4.2 UK Government: Statements	18
4.3 UK Government: Military actions and bases	20
4.4 UK Parliament: Debate and response	24

Summary and background

This research briefing is not intended to provide detailed information on fast-moving events.

Due to the ongoing conflict and restricted internet and media access within Iran, civilian and military casualties and reports on specific events can be difficult to verify.

On 28 February 2026, [Israel and the United States began a series of strikes against Iran](#). They said they aimed to induce regime change and target its nuclear and ballistic missile programme. A conditional ceasefire was declared on 8 April. [Talks are being mediated by Pakistan](#)].

In response to the attack, Iran launched a series of counter-strikes against Israel, US military bases in the region, and military and civilian locations in Arab states, many of which house US forces. UK bases in [Bahrain](#), [Qatar](#) and [Cyprus](#) were attacked and the RAF was deployed in a defensive capacity.

This briefing sets out US and Israeli statements on their decisions to launch the attacks, the Iranian regime's response, the death of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and selection of his son as his successor, and UK actions and response to the conflict. This includes information on UK defensive military action, diplomatic initiatives and UN action, and responses within the UK Parliament. A [separate briefing describes talks on an agreement in 2026](#).

Iran's internal and regional position is weak

The attacks came when the Iranian regime was arguably at its weakest point for some years:

- There were [extensive protests in Iran in early 2026](#), motivated by a [weakened economy as well as struggling infrastructure](#), illustrating the regime's weakened legitimacy within the country. The protests were put down with extensive use of force. [Arrests have continued in the conflict](#).
- Many of [Iran's regional allies have been significantly weakened](#), primarily by Israeli military action from 2023.
- [Israeli military strikes in 2024 and joint strikes with the US over 12 days in 2025](#) undermined Iran's defences and nuclear programme.
- Iran's counter-strikes on Arab Gulf states in 2026, [who have sought to deepen relations in recent years](#), may also leave it further isolated.

The attacks also follow the [failure of indirect negotiations in February 2026](#) on a new agreement to curtail Iran's nuclear programme. The [mediating Omani foreign minister had stated significant progress](#), with Iran willing to make concessions, but [President Trump said he was "not thrilled" with the talks](#).

Statements by US, Iran and Hezbollah actions

The [US said its attacks were in line with the right to self-defence](#) under the UN charter until the UN Security Council takes action. It has [accused Iran of continuing to advance its nuclear and ballistic missile programmes](#). President [Trump has called for the overthrow of the governing regime](#) but has since said [regime change has occurred](#), though he says he distrusts Iran's new leader.

The [Iranian Government condemned the US-Israel attacks](#) as a breach of the UN charter and said [it would exercise the right to self-defence](#). Iranian officials said that [Israel](#) and [US bases across the region](#) would be targeted.

Iran-backed Hezbollah in Lebanon has also attacked Israel in support of Iran, [causing the Lebanese Government to ban Hezbollah's military activities](#) and [Israel to launch military operations](#). Since the 2023/24 Israel-Hezbollah conflict, [the Lebanese Government has sought to disarm Hezbollah](#), but the group retains extensive weaponry and some support in Shia communities. In mid-April, [separate talks arranged a ceasefire, extended to late May](#).

The Strait of Hormuz

In response to the attacks, Iran said [it would shut the Strait of Hormuz, a major oil and trading route](#). While a small number of ships permitted by Iran have continued to use the strait, [almost all shipping has ceased](#).

The US responded by [temporarily removing sanctions on some Russian oil](#) and [Iranian oil](#) already in transit. Exemptions for Iran expired in mid-April. The 32 members of the International Energy Agency, including the UK, have also [released 400 million barrels of oil in an attempt to lower prices](#).

On 13 April, the US launched a counter-blockade of the Strait, [targeting all ships seeking to reach Iranian ports](#). The reopening of the strait is a major issue in the Pakistani-mediated talks. [Iran has threatened military action](#) if the US blockade does not end. [President Trump has threatened extensive attacks on Iranian infrastructure](#) if Iran does not reopen the Strait.

The [separate Library briefing on the strait](#) sets out international initiatives.

UK response and defensive military action

UK calls for ceasefire to be adhered to

On 28 February 2026, in a [joint statement with the leaders of France and Germany](#), the Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer condemned the Iranian counter-

strikes and called for a resumption of diplomacy. The leaders reiterated their shared positions that the Iranian regime should end its nuclear programme, curtail its ballistic missile programme, end the repression of Iranians, and stop its support for armed groups abroad. The [Prime Minister said he did “not believe in regime change from the skies”](#). The government [also called for an end to military operations in Lebanon](#) by Israel and Hezbollah.

UK military operations are defensive

The [UK did not participate militarily in the strikes](#). UK aircraft have been deployed in a defensive role to intercept missiles and projectiles, including in [Qatar](#), [Jordan](#), [Iraq](#) and [Cyprus](#). Among the measures the UK has taken include [deploying HMS Dragon to Cyprus](#), [four additional jets to Qatar](#) and air defences to [Bahrain](#), [Kuwait](#) and [Saudi Arabia](#).

On 1 March 2026, the Prime Minister also said that the [US could use UK military bases for a “specific and limited defensive purpose”](#), which he said was to “destroy the [Iranian] missiles at source”. On 20 March the government said that [US use of the bases also includes](#) “US defensive operations to degrade the missile sites and capabilities being used to attack ships” in Hormuz. [Bases to be used](#) are Diego Garcia (British Indian Ocean Territory/Chagos Archipelago) and RAF Fairford (Gloucestershire).

The [government published summary legal advice on its decision](#) and the continuing RAF operations, saying the actions are in self-defence.

March 2026 UN Security Council resolution

On 11 March, [the UN Security Council passed a resolution](#) demanding the end of attacks by Iran and its proxies against Arab states and civilians and “reaffirming” the right of ships to traverse the Strait of Hormuz. This was first proposed by the Arab Gulf states. [China and Russia abstained](#) on the resolution. [The UK voted in favour](#) of the resolution.

1

United States and Israeli strikes

The US and Israel launched strikes on Iran on 28 February 2026. In late March the US said it was close to achieving its aims. A two-week conditional ceasefire was announced on 8 April. Talks are ongoing, under Pakistan mediation. See the [separate Library briefing: US-Iran talks 2026](#).

1.1

What reasons did the US give for the strikes?

US administration concerns for Iran's ballistic and nuclear programme

In a [statement on Truth Social](#), posted on 28 February 2026, President Trump set out that Iran posed a threat to “core national security interests of the US”. He said:¹

- the US had been unable to [reach a diplomatic agreement with Iran in February 2026](#) to curtail its nuclear programme
- the Iranian regime was instead continuing to expand its nuclear and ballistic missile programme
- the US would not allow Iran to develop a nuclear weapon

President Trump said that the military action would “annihilate” the Iranian navy, destroy Iran's missile sites and programme, and weaken the network of Iran-backed terrorist and armed groups across the region.

The US told the UN Security Council that the action was taken under Article 51 of the UN charter (referring to [self-defence until the council takes action](#)) and that Iran had been in breach of several UN Security Council resolutions, such as those limiting its nuclear programme.²

Assessments of Iran's nuclear and missile programmes

Speaking in February, President Trump reiterated his assessment that [the joint US-Israel military action carried out in June 2025](#) had “totally obliterated” Iranian nuclear sites. Some eight months on, however, the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) has been unable to resume inspections in Iran and the location of Iran's highly enriched uranium has not been ascertained, though much is expected to be at underground facilities in Isfahan, in central Iran.³

In March 2026, the President's envoy to the Middle East, Steve Witkoff, had also noted Iran's “breakout time” (the time taken to develop enough fissile material for a nuclear weapon) to be a few weeks.⁴ This has [long been noted](#)

¹ Times of Israel, [Full text of Trump's declaration \[...\] against Iran](#), 28 February 2026

² US Mission to the UN, [Remarks at an emergency \[...\] briefing](#) and [Additional remarks \[...\]](#), both 28 February 2026. See Israeli and US letters: [S/2026/161](#) and [S/2026/162](#), 10 March 2026.

³ Reuters, [IAEA report says Iran must allow inspections, points at Isfahan](#), 27 February 2026 and [Much of Iran's near-bomb-grade uranium likely to be in Isfahan](#), 9 March 2026

⁴ Fox News, [Witkoff warns there was 'almost no stopping' Iran from enriching uranium](#), 3 March 2026

Analysts judge Iran is not currently building a nuclear weapon

by the IAEA. It has been estimated that the “weaponisation” time (putting the material on a deliverable warhead) would be much longer.

Iran has said it does not seek a nuclear weapon, though [its enrichment level is above that needed for civilian uses](#) and there has been greater public debate in Iran proposing such a move. The 2025 US intelligence community assessment had judged Iran was not building a nuclear weapon.⁵ In March 2026, the IAEA head, Rafael Grossi, said that while Iran has a “very big ambitious nuclear program [...] we don’t see a structured program to manufacture nuclear weapons”.⁶

On Iran’s ballistic missile programme, a March 2026 report by the US intelligence community assessed that Iran had “developed space-launch vehicles that it could use to develop a military-viable ICBM by 2035”, but it had not decided to.⁷

Iranian missile range is extensive, being capable of reaching sites across the Middle East and parts of southern Europe, at around 1,200 miles. The US Congressional Research Service report, [Iran’s ballistic missile programs](#) and Center for Strategic and International Studies, [Missiles of Iran](#), has further details.

Missiles targeted Diego Garcia in March 2026

Analysts judge that Iran’s firing of two missiles in March 2026 targeting Diego Garcia on the British Indian Ocean Territory/Chagos Archipelago (around 2,500 miles from Iran) as [primarily posing a psychological and political threat](#) rather than a military one. Of the two missiles, one was intercepted and the other failed mid-flight.⁸ The UK Defence Secretary said they fell “well short” of the target, and the UK Government would not comment further.⁹

Statements on regime change or new Supreme Leader

On 28 February, the US President also called on Iranians, “when we are finished, to take over your government”.¹⁰

Following the announcement of the death of Iran’s Supreme Leader, Ali Khamenei, President Trump called on the Iranian security forces and the [Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps](#) (IRGC) to lay down their arms and “peacefully merge with the Iranian patriots”.¹¹

However, the US President also suggested that Iran could choose a successor to the supreme leader. In an interview with the New York Times, he described

⁵ US Office of Director of National Intelligence, [2025 annual threat assessment \[...\]](#), March 2025

⁶ UN Media, [IAEA/Grossi board of governors](#), 2 March 2026

⁷ US Defence Intelligence Agency, [DIA releases “golden dome” threat assessment](#), 13 May 2025; US Office of Director of National Intelligence, [2026 annual threat assessment \[...\]](#), 2026, p18

⁸ The Times, [Can Iranian missiles reach the UK and could our defences stop them?](#), 22 March 2026

⁹ HC Deb, [23 March 2026](#), c39

¹⁰ Times of Israel, [Full text of Trump’s declaration \[...\] against Iran](#), 28 February 2026

¹¹ Truth Social Donald Trump, [“Khamenei \[...\] is dead”](#), 28 February 2026

“what we did in Venezuela [as] the perfect scenario [...] [where] everybody’s kept their job except for two people”.¹² This [refers to the US capture of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro and his wife](#) in January 2026 and the swearing in of his vice president as his successor.

On 25 March, after Ali Khamenei’s son had been selected as his successor, the US President said that there had been “a change in the regime because the leaders are different to the ones that caused all those problems”, though he said he did not trust them.¹³

1.2

Israeli Government statements

On 28 February, Israel’s Defence Minister, Israel Katz, said that the country’s armed forces had launched “pre-emptive attack” on Iran.¹⁴

In his statement announcing the operation, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu echoed many of President Trump’s comments, saying that Iran was seeking to rebuild its nuclear programme and missile capabilities. He said Iran was potentially “months” from completing sufficient underground bunkers to make their missile and nuclear programmes “immune”.¹⁵

The Prime Minister said that the operations would “continue as long as necessary” and called on Iranians to “take their destiny into their own hands”.¹⁶ Later, on 23 March, he said that a potential agreement with Iran could “leverage the tremendous achievements we have reached alongside the US military to realize the goals of the war through an agreement”.¹⁷

1.3

What have the US and Israel targeted in Iran?

The [US says that it targeted Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps \(IRGC\) facilities](#), air defences, drone launch sites, and airfields. Other sites targeted by the US and Israel have included [missile sites, navy and nuclear facilities](#), and [Iranian internal security sites](#) and governing institutions.¹⁸

The US-based Institute for Study of War provided daily updates on the conflict as part of its [Iran update series](#). The UN Office for Coordination of

¹² New York Times, [Trump\[...\]offers contradictory visions of new regime](#), 1 March 2026

¹³ Evening Standard, [Trump fuels hopes his Iran war will end soon \[...\]](#), 24 March 2026

¹⁴ Times of Israel, [Israel has launched a pre-emptive attack on Iran](#), 28 February 2026

¹⁵ Times of Israel, [PM: Iran’s nuke program would have been ‘immune in months’](#), 3 March 2026

¹⁶ Times of Israel, [Full text of Netanyahu’s message as Israel, US strike Iran](#), 28 February 2026

¹⁷ Israeli Foreign Office, [Statement by PM Netanyahu](#), 23 March 2026

¹⁸ US Department of War, [Secretary of War and Chairman \[...\]](#), 4 March 2026

Humanitarian Affairs also published a summary as [Islamic Republic of Iran: Humanitarian update](#), 6 April 2026 (using Iranian government data).

President Trump said that the US would expand its operations and launch extensive strikes on Iranian bridges and power plants from 6 April if the Hormuz Strait was not reopened to shipping. However, the two parties later agreed to talks.¹⁹

Speaking on 8 April, the US Chairman of the Joint Chiefs, General Dan Caine, said that the US had “achieved the military objectives” set by the President, namely to destroy Iran’s ballistic missile and drone capabilities, their navy, and the defence industrial base that Iran will need to reconstitute its armed forces and defences.²⁰ He reported that the US had:

- destroyed around 80% of Iran's air defence systems. These included ballistic missile storage and one-way attack drones storage facilities and command centres
- sunk more than 90% of Iran’s regular fleet and 95% of their naval mines
- attacked 90% of Iran’s weapons factories, including all sites manufacturing Shaheed one-way attack drones.
- hit 80% of Iran’s nuclear industrial base.²¹

These attacks follow those of June 2025, in which the US and Israel assessed that they had destroyed Iran’s nuclear facilities—see the Commons Library briefing [Iran: Impacts of June 2025 Israel and US strikes](#), July 2025. In the 2026 conflict, the IAEA has said several sites related to Iran’s nuclear programme have been damaged, but no nuclear material has been released into the atmosphere.²²

2 Counter-strikes and attacks by Iran and its allies

On 28 February, the Iranian Government condemned the US-Israel attacks as a breach of the UN charter and said it would exercise the right to self-defence

¹⁹ Truth Social Donald Trump, “[Tuesday will be power plant day](#)”, 5 April 2026

²⁰ US Department of War, [Secretary of War and Chairman \[...\] press briefing](#), 6 April 2026

²¹ US Department of War, [Secretary of War and Chairman \[...\] press briefing](#), 6 April 2026

²² IAEA on Twitter/X, “[Based on the latest available satellite imagery](#)”, 3 March 2026; IAEA on Twitter/X, “[Based on independent analysis of satellite imagery \[...\]](#)”, 29 March 2026; Times of Israel, [IDF confirms strike on yellowcake plant in Iran](#), 27 March 2026; BBC News, [Nuclear watchdog calls for 'maximum military restraint' after power plant incident](#), 4 April 2026

for as long as the attacks continue.²³ It launched attacks on Israel, US bases across the region, as well as on Arab states across the Middle East.

2.1

Iranian counter-strikes and Strait of Hormuz

How has the Arab Gulf responded?

Arab Gulf states ([Saudi Arabia](#), [the UAE](#), [Kuwait](#), [Oman](#), [Qatar](#) and [Bahrain](#)) have all condemned Iranian attacks but also, in the case of [Oman](#), criticised the US-Israel attacks. They have accused Iran of a breach of the UN charter and said they reserve the right to respond.²⁴

Saudi Arabia and Qatar requested some Iranian diplomats leave the country in response to the attacks. Qatar has historically mediated between Iran and other countries (such as the US). Saudi Arabia last cut off diplomatic ties with Iran in 2015.²⁵ The UAE also closed its embassy in Iran on 1 March.²⁶

Oman's Foreign Minister has also described the Iranian attacks as "completely unacceptable" but "probably the only rational option" to the US and Israeli strikes. He said that the US has "lost control of its own foreign policy" and "its friends" must tell it that "the national interests of both Iran and America lie in the earliest possible end to hostilities" and new talks.²⁷

The states had reportedly lobbied the US against launching military action.²⁸

What has Iran targeted?

The Iranian counter-strikes targeted Israel and US forces, but also neighbouring Arab states.²⁹ UK bases in Cyprus, Iraq and Bahrain have also been targeted. There have been no reported UK casualties. There have also been Iranian drones or missiles in [Turkish airspace](#) and [Azerbaijan](#).

Countries targeted by Iranian counter-strikes include Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Oman, Iraq and Jordan. The UAE was the

²³ Iran Foreign Ministry, [Iran requests UN action against Israeli and US aggression](#), 1 March 2026; UN, [UN Security Council meeting in emergency session](#), 28 February 2026

²⁴ Gulf Cooperation Council, [Statement issued by the 50th Extraordinary Meeting](#), 1 March 2026

²⁵ Al Jazeera, Saudi [Arabia expels Iran military attaché, four embassy staff](#), 21 March 2026; Qatari Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Qatar declares Iranian embassy \[...\] attaches \[...\]](#), 1 March 2026

²⁶ Emirates News Agency, [UAE announces closure of embassy in Tehran](#), 1 March 2026

²⁷ The Economist, [America's friends must help extricate it from an unlawful war](#), 18 March 2026

²⁸ Foreign Policy, [The United States could lose the Gulf](#), 5 March 2026

²⁹ BBC News, [Allies of US in the Gulf bear brunt of Iran attacks](#), 1 March 2026

most targeted (the Institute for the Study of War provides comparative data in its [Iran update special report](#), 30 March 2026). US military assets in these countries have been targeted, [alongside civilian sites such as airports, banks, and oil and energy infrastructure](#). These caused several states to suspend oil and gas production and trade.

On 7 March, Iran's President, Masoud Pezeshkian, said he "personally apologise[s] to neighbouring countries that were attacked by Iran". However, wider Iranian strikes on Gulf states continued and he later said his remarks focused on civilian casualties.³⁰

Iran was likely to have been seeking to exert maximum political and energy price pressure through its attacks on the Arab Gulf and hindering of the global oil trade, even if this threatens its long-term relationships with Gulf states.³¹

Actions in the Strait of Hormuz

During the conflict, Iran has also announced a blockade of shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow strait of water in the Persian Gulf through which around a quarter of the world's trade flows. While direct attacks on shipping have been few, the vast majority of movement through the strait has ended.

The Library briefing, [Israel/US-Iran conflict 2026: Reopening the Strait of Hormuz](#) sets out the importance of the strait to the global economy, Iranian and US action in the strait, including its counter-blockade on Iranian ports, and UK and international initiatives to reopen the trade route.

2.2

Actions of Iran-backed armed groups

Iran has long maintained a [network of allied armed and terrorist groups](#) across the Middle East with one aim being to act as a "forward defence" network capable of threatening US interests.

However, the military capacity and strategic initiative of two major allied groups, [Hamas in Gaza](#) and [Hezbollah in Lebanon](#), has been [significantly degraded](#) over the 2023 to 2025 conflicts in the Middle East. Hamas has not participated militarily in the 2026 conflict.³²

³⁰ Al Jazeera, [Why are Iranian leaders sending mixed messages on Gulf attacks?](#), 8 March 2026; BBC Monitoring, [Iranian president clarifies his apology to neighbours](#), 8 March 2026

³¹ BBC Monitoring, [Does Iran prefer a prolonged war to a ceasefire?](#), 9 March 2026

³² BBC Monitoring, [Hamas calls on Iran to avoid targeting neighbouring countries](#), 14 March 2026

Renewed Israel–Hezbollah conflict in Lebanon

For UK aid and statements on Lebanon, see section 4.2

Hezbollah strikes and Israeli ground offensive

On 2 March 2026 Hezbollah launched a missile attack on Israel. Israel initially responded with a series of air strikes and subsequently launched a ground offensive in border areas to “seize a front line of defence”. It called for civilians to [evacuate large parts of southern Lebanon, up to the Zahrani river](#) (around 25 miles north of the [Blue Line between Israel and Lebanon](#)).³³

Israel has said it will maintain control of a “security zone” in southern Lebanon, up to the Litani River (20 miles into Lebanon), until the threat of Hezbollah is removed.³⁴ Defence Minister Israel Katz said displaced Lebanese in the south of the country “will not be allowed to return until the security of northern [Israel] residents is guaranteed”.³⁵

President Aoun of Lebanon has described Israeli attacks on bridges in the country as a “prelude to ground invasion”.³⁶

Humanitarian situation

As of 24 March, over one million Lebanese citizens were displaced, or around a sixth of the population. Lebanon has been experiencing a severe economic crisis in recent years (see the [Library briefing on the country](#)).³⁷

The UN has launched a US\$308 million appeal for Lebanon.³⁸ Its [flash appeal page](#) and [UNOCHA’s “flash” humanitarian reports](#) for Lebanon provide information on casualties, displacement and humanitarian need.

2024/25 ceasefire plan and disarming Hezbollah

The renewed conflict in Lebanon is despite the ceasefire agreement of 2024 and [Lebanese Government attempts to disarm Hezbollah](#) and its condemnation of Iran’s attacks on Israel from February 2026.³⁹

³³ New Arab, [Israeli strike Lebanon \[...\]](#), 2 March 2026; Times of Israel, [IDF strikes in Beirut](#), 2 March 2026; BBC News, [Israel says it will take control of large buffer zone in southern Lebanon](#), 24 March 2026; BBC News, [Fear and defiance in southern Lebanon city](#), 17 March 2026

³⁴ Times of Israel, [Katz says Israel will hold ‘security zone’ in Lebanon](#), 24 March 2026; Reuters, [Israel to establish buffer zone in south Lebanon up to Litani River](#), 31 March 2026

³⁵ Washington Post, [Israel kills scores in Beirut](#), 8 April 2026

³⁶ Al Jazeera, [Lebanon’s Aoun warns Israeli attack on bridge ‘prelude \[...\]](#)’, 22 March 2026

³⁷ UN Refugee Agency, [Middle East situation report](#), 25 March 2026; BBC Monitoring, [How war-driven displacement in Lebanon is widening social fractures](#), 23 March 2026

³⁸ UN, [UN chief launches major humanitarian appeal from war-torn Lebanon](#), 13 March 2026

³⁹ Wall Street Journal, [Lebanese Prime Minister condemns Hezbollah strikes on Israel](#), 1 March 2026

See the Library briefing [Lebanon 2025: Plans to disarm Hezbollah](#) (September 2025)

Since 2025, the Lebanese armed forces have moved cautiously to disarm Hezbollah, which [retains significant support among Shia Muslim communities in Lebanon](#) as well as a substantial arsenal of weapons and has had some support from Iran to rearm and reorganise. However, there were divisions with Hezbollah and its allied groups over its decision to attack Israel.⁴⁰

Hezbollah described the Lebanese Government's action as "misplaced" and has since continued its attacks on Israel.⁴¹ Analysis by BBC Monitoring published on 20 March notes Hezbollah retains significant military strength, reporting that that "Hezbollah's claimed daily intensity of attacks in early March 2026 appears far higher than the average in the 2023-2024 conflict [between Israel and Hamas]".⁴²

On 2 March the Lebanese Government said it would ban Hezbollah's military activities, and the group should now hand over all its weapons to the state. Hezbollah has previously said [it will only disarm if there is full Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon](#).⁴³

The Lebanese Government has also said it is seeking to limit IRGC military activities in the country and has asked the Iranian ambassador to leave, though the decision has created disagreement among leading politicians in Lebanon and Iran has refused to recall its ambassador. The IRGC has long provided support to Hezbollah.⁴⁴

Israel-Lebanon ceasefire talks from April

The US and Israel said that the conditional ceasefire announced on 8 April and mediated by Pakistan did not include Lebanon, though the Lebanese Government, as well as European governments including that of the UK, have said that it must be included.⁴⁵

Separate negotiations are being held under US mediation between the governments of Israel and Lebanon.⁴⁶ Hezbollah and Israeli fighting continued, despite the talks, until the US announced on 16 April that a ten-day ceasefire had been agreed. On 23 April, the ceasefire was extended a further three weeks.⁴⁷

⁴⁰ BBC Monitoring, [Hezbollah's escalation against Israel lays bare internal rifts](#), 5 March 2026; Reuters, [How Iran's IRGC rebooted Lebanon's Hezbollah to be ready for war](#), 21 March 2026

⁴¹ BBC Monitoring, [Hezbollah rejects government ban](#), 3 March 2026

⁴² BBC Monitoring, [Hezbollah maintains military capability \[...\]](#), 20 March 2026

⁴³ Naharnet, [Cabinet bans Hezbollah military activities \[...\]](#), 2 March 2026

⁴⁴ BBC Monitoring, [Lebanon bans IRGC](#), 5 March 2026; Al Monitor, [In Lebanon, deadline looms for expelling Iran envoy](#), 26 March 2026; Reuters, [Iran says envoy will remain in Beirut](#), 30 March 2026

⁴⁵ New York Times, [Vance says Lebanon was never part of cease-fire deal](#), 8 April 2026; FCDO, [Foreign Secretary's statement: ceasefire in the Middle East](#), 8 April 2026; European Council, [Leaders' statement on the two-week ceasefire concluded between the US and Iran](#), 8 April 2026

⁴⁶ US State Department, [Meeting \[...\] of the US, Lebanon, and Israel](#), 14 April 2026

⁴⁷ Truth Social Donald Trump, ["I just had excellent conversations"](#), 16 April 2026 and ["The President of the United States"](#), 23 April 2026

The US said that Israel seeks the disarming of Hezbollah within Lebanon and resolution of other outstanding issues (these could include borders, which remain unresolved, as well as [normalisation of diplomatic relations](#), which are not in place). Lebanon's government called for the "full implementation" of the 2024 agreement with Israel (see above).⁴⁸

The US State Department has [published the six-point agreement](#) between the Lebanese and Israeli governments. It says that the ceasefire period can be extended, that Israel retains the right to take action in self-defence, and that the Lebanese armed forces hold "exclusive responsibility for Lebanon's sovereignty and national defence" and will take steps to contain Hezbollah and armed groups in the country.⁴⁹

Hezbollah has signalled it will adhere to the agreement but says it wants Israel to withdraw from Lebanon.⁵⁰ The agreement does not require this. Prime Minister Netanyahu has said that the Israel Defence Forces will remain in a 10km-deep border area to protect northern Israel from attack.⁵¹

Further reading on Lebanon

- Foreign Affairs, [Lebanon's coming collapse: An Israeli assault is pushing the fragile country to the brink](#), 3 April 2026
- Chatham House, [Any Israeli occupation of southern Lebanon will work to Hezbollah's advantage](#), 25 March 2026
- International Crisis Group, [Where is the Israel-Hizbollah war going?](#), 20 March 2026
- Italian Institute for International Political Studies, [Lebanon on the brink: Hezbollah, Israel and a nation under strain](#), March 2026

Houthis in Yemen

The Houthis in Yemen remain a substantive force and [control the majority of Yemen](#). While they condemned the attack on Iran and backed its counter-

⁴⁸ US State Department, [Meeting \[...\] of the US, Lebanon, and Israel](#), 14 April 2026

⁴⁹ US State Department, [Ten day cessation of hostilities](#), 16 April 2026

⁵⁰ BBC Monitoring, [Hezbollah warns it will resume fighting Israel if ceasefire is breached](#), 17 April 2026; BBC News, [Hezbollah says temporary ceasefire has 'no practical significance'](#), 18 April 2026

⁵¹ Israeli Ministry of Foreign Affairs, [PM Netanyahu's statement on Lebanon and Iran](#), 16 April 2026

attacks, they have not [resumed attacks on Red Sea shipping](#), as they did in support of Hamas in Gaza from 2023.

From 27 March to 6 April, the Houthis claimed six attacks on Israel.⁵² These have since ceased. The group's actions did not include attacks on Red Sea shipping or attacks on Arab Gulf states ([as it has done in the past](#)).

Pro-Iran militias in Iraq

Some pro-Iran militias in Iraq launched attacks across Iraq, including against US military bases and the US embassy in Baghdad.⁵³ They have said they will adhere to the conditional ceasefire announced on 8 April.⁵⁴

Many Iraqi MPs have renewed their calls for the country reconsider its security pact with the US. [US troops are intended to be drawn down and their mission to end in most of Iraq by September 2026](#). On its part, the US has restated its calls for Iran-backed militias in Iraq to be dismantled and disarmed.⁵⁵

3

Situation in Iran and new leader

Background and further resources on Iran

The Commons Library [introductory country profile on Iran](#) provides information on Iran's political system, economy, human rights and historic foreign relations. This includes with the UK, the US and Arab Gulf states.

Iranian officials have confirmed that Ali Khamenei was killed while at his office in the capital, Tehran. He has been Iranian Supreme Leader since 1989, succeeding Ruhollah Khomeini who led Iran after the last Shah was overthrown in the Iranian revolution of 1979.⁵⁶ Ali Khamenei was 86, and the Iranian state had been planning for a potential succession for some time.⁵⁷

⁵² BBC Monitoring, [Yemen's Houthis claim responsibility for sixth attack on Israel](#), 6 April 2026

⁵³ Soufan Center, [Iraq unable to avoid the US-Iran crossfire](#), 16 March 2026

⁵⁴ Ashraq Al-Awsat, [Pro-Iran armed factions in Iraq announce two-week halt in attacks](#), 8 April 2026

⁵⁵ See Commons Library briefing, [Introductory country profile: Iraq](#), sections 3 and 6 and BBC Monitoring, [Iraqi MPs seek to scrap US security pact](#), 15 March 2026 and [US urges Iraq to dismantle pro-Iran militias](#), 14 March 2026

⁵⁶ AP News, [Iran's supreme leader killed in major attack by US and Israel](#), 1 March 2026

⁵⁷ Arab Gulf States Institute, [Iran: Emergence of collective leadership](#), 23 June 2025

3.1

Leadership and new Supreme Leader

Khamenei's son appointed Supreme Leader

On 8 March, Iran's Assembly of Experts announced Mojtaba Khamenei would succeed his father as the country's supreme leader. Aged 56, analysts judge him close to the IRGC and likely to continue his father's policies.⁵⁸ In 2019, he had been sanctioned by the US for "advance[ing] his father's destabilising regional ambitions and oppressive domestic objectives".⁵⁹

Since taking office, Mojtaba Khamenei has not appeared in public and there has been speculation over his health and authority.⁶⁰

UK, Israeli and US reaction

The UK Government says that his selection "suggests no change in direction from Iran".⁶¹

President Trump has said he opposes Mojtaba Khamenei succeeding his father as supreme leader or any figure who would continue Ali Khamenei's policies.⁶²

Israel's Defence Minister, Israel Katz, has said that any new Iranian leader who continues "the plan to destroy Israel, to threaten the United States" and "suppress the Iranian people" will be "an unequivocal target for elimination".⁶³ After the April ceasefire was announced, he said that Israel was "awaiting a green light from the United States [to attack Iran], first and foremost to complete the elimination of the Khamenei dynasty".⁶⁴

Many of Iran's leaders have been killed

In both the [2024 Israeli strikes and 2025 US-Israel strikes on Iran](#), many senior leaders in Iran's IRGC, armed forces and other security services have been killed. These include, in 2026, the army chief of staff, secretary of the National Security Council, defence and intelligence ministers, and IRGC commanders.⁶⁵

However, as set out in the Commons Library [introductory country profile on Iran](#), Iran's political system is based not solely on the Supreme Leader but a network of institutions and organisations, including a president, guardian

⁵⁸ AP News, [Iran names Mojtaba Khamenei to succeed his father](#), 9 March 2026

⁵⁹ US Treasury Department, [Treasury designates supreme leader of Iran's inner circle](#), 4 November 2019

⁶⁰ BBC Monitoring, [New Iran leader's absence weakens efforts to consolidate power](#), 3 April 2026

⁶¹ HL Deb, [9 March 2026](#), c14

⁶² Axios, [Trump says he must be involved in picking Iran's next leader](#), 5 March 2026

⁶³ BBC News, [\[...\] Israel warns it may try to kill his successor](#), 4 March 2026

⁶⁴ Times of Israel, [Katz says Israel waiting for 'green light' to renew war against Iran](#), 23 April 2026

⁶⁵ Times of Israel, [These are the key Iranian figures killed \[...\]](#), 19 March 2026

council, parliament, clerical leaders and the IRGC. Analysts judge that this gives the Iranian regime greater flexibility and capacity to absorb losses (though [wider societal issues remain unresolved](#)).⁶⁶

While Iran may benefit financially from increased oil prices during the conflict, over the longer term its economic challenges may be greater, reflecting the worsening of its relations with the Gulf and extensive reconstruction costs and higher inflation, perhaps reaching 50% in March (see the UN Development Programme report, [Military escalation in the Middle East: Impacts on Iran](#), 31 March 2026). One Iranian official said that around one million Iranians were made unemployed due to the conflict. The internet shut down (see below) may have cost the economy around £28 million a day.⁶⁷

On 18 March, the US Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard said that the US intelligence community (containing the major intelligence agencies) “assesses the regime in Iran appears to be intact, but largely degraded”. She said that “internal tensions are likely to increase as Iran’s economy worsens” but, if the regime survives, “it will seek to begin a yearslong effort to rebuild its missiles and UAV [drone] forces”.⁶⁸

3.2 Iranian society

No internet access

Since the strikes began, [internet access has been severely limited in Iran](#), making it hard for journalists to report and verify the situation within the country. International media are often banned from Iran.

Population displacement

On 26 March, the Iranian Government said that between 600,000 and one million households had been displaced within Iran, with an estimated total of 1.9 million to 3 million individuals. The UN Refugee Agency has reported relatively small numbers of Iranians leaving the country, with lower numbers crossing the Turkey–Iran border than the pre-conflict average.⁶⁹

⁶⁶ BBC Monitoring, [Why have weeks of war failed to trigger Iran regime change?](#) and [Inside Iran's wartime power structure](#), 26 March 2026

⁶⁷ Bloomberg, [Iran oil revenue soars as it's the only Exporter out of Hormuz](#), 26 March 2026; RUSI, [The real test for Iran comes after the war](#), 2 April 2026; BBC News, [Iran sees mass redundancies](#), 21 April 2026

⁶⁸ BBC News, [US intelligence chief says Iran's regime “intact” but “degraded”](#), 18 March 2026; Senate Intelligence Committee, [“Present the 2026 Annual Threat Assessment”](#) (PDF), March 2026

⁶⁹ UN Refugee Agency, [Up to 3.2 million Iranians temporarily displaced in Iran](#), 12 March 2026 and [Situation report-Middle East](#) (accessed 26 March 2026)

Arrests and repression

[Extensive protests were held in Iran in early 2026](#), initially sparked by deteriorating economic conditions. Human rights groups report that state security forces conducted thousands of arrests and several thousand people were killed by security forces (numbers are still being verified). During the conflict, Iranian leaders have issued warnings against further protests.

Many arrests have been reported, [including on charges of spying for Israel](#). Others detained have been accused of links to foreign-based opposition groups, media outlets, and espionage networks. The continuing internet shut down has hindered coordination and mobilisation for any potential protests.⁷⁰

The Iranian Government has also said that it seeks to confiscate assets from Iranians abroad who express support for Israel or the United States.⁷¹

4 UK response to the 2026 conflict

4.1 UK backs UN Security Council resolution

The UN Security Council met in emergency session on 28 February 2026. There has been no resolution or vote before the military strikes commenced. A separate resolution on Hormuz has not passed, with a draft vetoed by Russia and China on 7 April 2026: see the [separate Library briefing on the strait](#).

UN Secretary General statements

UN Secretary General, António Guterres, described the US-Israeli strikes as “squandering” an opportunity for diplomacy and condemned both their actions and the counter-strikes of Iran. He also restated that article 2 of the UN Charter says:

All Members shall refrain in their international relations from the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any state.⁷²

Arab Gulf state resolution passes, March 2026

In March 2026 the UN Security Council considered two draft resolutions on the conflict. One was drafted by Russia ([S/2026/159](#)), and did not pass, and the second was drafted by Bahrain and the Gulf Co-operation Council (GCC) and

⁷⁰ BBC Monitoring, [Iran intensifies crackdown amid US-Israeli strikes on day 24](#), 23 March 2026; Reuters, [Iran arrests 466 people accused of online activity \[...\]](#), 24 March 2026

⁷¹ Press TV, [Judicial proceedings begin to seize assets of Iranians abroad](#), 10 March 2026

⁷² UN, [Secretary-General's remarks to the Security Council meeting](#), 28 February 2026

had the support of around 135 UN member states.⁷³ This second measure ([S/RES/2817\(2026\)](#)) passed, though Russia and China abstained.⁷⁴ Neither resolution referred to Israel or US military action.

The successful resolution said that the Security Council demanded the end of attacks by Iran and its proxies against Arab states and civilians:

Demands the immediate cessation of all attacks by the Islamic Republic of Iran against Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and Jordan;

Demands that the Islamic Republic of Iran immediately and unconditionally cease from any provocation or threats to neighbouring States, including the use of proxies.⁷⁵

The council also “reaffirmed” the right of ships to traverse the Strait of Hormuz, and that states can act in self-defence to defend their vessels from attacks. The resolution did not endorse any action in the strait but said the council “condemn[ed]” Iranian action.⁷⁶

UK, US and Russian statements on the resolution

The UK backed the Bahrain-drafted resolution, saying that “Iran must cease these attacks and must not threaten [...] international security”.⁷⁷ It described the Russian resolution as a “distract[ion]” and “does nothing” to counter Iranian attacks in the region.⁷⁸

The US told the Security Council that Russia was “protect[ing] its partner, Iran”, through its draft resolution.⁷⁹

Russia described the GCC resolution as “one-side[d]”.⁸⁰

4.2

UK Government: Statements

Backed conditional ceasefire, 7 April 2026

Following the announcement of a two-week ceasefire by Pakistan, Iran, Israel and the US on 7 April ([subsequently extended](#)) the UK Government welcomed the agreement and talks in Pakistan. The government called for a “full end” to

⁷³ Al Jazeera, [UN Security Council adopts resolution \[...\]](#), 12 March 2026

⁷⁴ UN Security Council Document, [S/PV.10119](#), 11 March 2026

⁷⁵ UN Security Council Document, [UNSC 2817 \(2026\)](#)

⁷⁶ UN Security Council Document, [UNSC 2817 \(2026\)](#)

⁷⁷ FCDO, [The adoption of this resolution sends a clear message \[...\]](#), 11 March 2026

⁷⁸ FCDO, [The draft Russian resolution does nothing to address the concerns](#), 11 March 2026

⁷⁹ US Mission to the UN, [Remarks on a Russian Federation drafted UN Security Council resolution \[...\] and Remarks on a Bahrain drafted UN Security Council resolution \[...\]](#), 11 March 2026

⁸⁰ UN Security Council, [S/PV.10119](#), 11 March 2026, p16

the conflict. The government welcomed the Lebanon ceasefire, agreed on 16 April, but said it should have been part of the original agreement.⁸¹

Criticised Iran and the US and called for diplomacy

On 28 February 2026, in a joint statement with the leaders of France and Germany, Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer condemned the Iranian counter-strikes and called for a resumption of diplomacy. All three leaders reiterated their shared positions that the Iranian regime should end its nuclear programme, curtail its ballistic missile programme, end the repression of Iranians, and stop its support for armed groups abroad.⁸²

The Prime Minister has also said that the “government [does] not believe in regime change from the skies”.⁸³

Speaking on 14 April, the Chancellor, Rachel Reeves, said that she was “very frustrated and angry that the US went into this war without a clear exit plan [and] without a clear idea of what they were trying to achieve”. She described this as “folly”.⁸⁴

The UK has criticised Iranian attacks on civilian locations in Bahrain, Kuwait and the UAE, among other sites.⁸⁵ The Prime Minister has spoken to leaders in [Cyprus](#), [Jordan](#), [Turkey](#), and had a three-day visit to the Gulf to meet regional leaders.⁸⁶ He said that the UK is seeking to “deepen our engagement on both defence and economic resilience” with the Gulf states.⁸⁷

On 4 and 23 March, the government also summoned the Iranian ambassador to the UK in response to the “escalatory behaviour by the Iranian regime” and the [charging of two Iranian individuals under the UK’s National Security Act](#).⁸⁸

Statement and actions on Lebanon and aid pledges

Alongside European foreign ministers, the Foreign Secretary, Yvette Cooper, called for Hezbollah to halt its attacks and both Israel and Hezbollah to “deescalate and to revert to the [2024] cessation of hostilities agreement”. The Foreign Secretary said that the UK Government would continue to support

⁸¹ FCDO, [Foreign Secretary's statement: ceasefire in the Middle East](#), 8 April 2026 and [Foreign Secretary statement on the Israel-Lebanon ceasefire](#), 17 April 2026

⁸² Prime Minister’s Office, [Joint E3 Leaders’ Statement on Iran](#), 28 February 2026

⁸³ HC Deb, [2 March 2026](#), c590

⁸⁴ Daily Mirror, [Rachel Reeves hits out at Donald Trump Iran war ‘folly’ hitting UK families](#), 14 April 2026

⁸⁵ FCDO, [UK statement at the UN Security Council](#), 28 February 2026

⁸⁶ Prime Minister’s Office, [PM meeting with Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia](#), 8 April 2026

⁸⁷ HC Deb, [13 April 2026](#), c349

⁸⁸ FCDO, [Summoning of the Iranian ambassador](#), 4 March 2026 and [Summoning of the Iranian Ambassador](#), 23 March 2026

the Lebanese Armed Forces to gain a monopoly on the use of force throughout Lebanon. The Prime Minister has said Hezbollah “must disarm”.⁸⁹

The government also said that “the forced displacement of 1 million Lebanese people as a result of Israeli operations is unacceptable”.⁹⁰ It has also restated its support for the [UN Interim Force in Lebanon \(UNIFIL\)](#), which monitors the “Blue Line” in southern Israel.⁹¹

The government has announced £29.5 million of aid to the Lebanese Red Cross, the UN Lebanon Humanitarian Fund and the World Food Programme to support the humanitarian response in the country in 2026. A further £7.5 million of aid will support the regional humanitarian response to the conflict.⁹²

Since 2009, the UK has contributed £180 million to support Lebanon’s security forces. This includes £120 million to the Lebanese Armed Forces.⁹³

UK diplomacy on Hormuz

Section 4 of the [Library briefing on the strait](#) provides information on UK initiatives to reopen the strait, including hosting two conferences in April.

Iranian activity in the UK

As of 19 April, [counter terrorism police in the UK are continuing to investigate Iranian state links to attacks](#) on Jewish communities in the UK. Attacks have included one on [four ambulances from Hatzola, a Jewish-led volunteer service](#). A group, [Harakat Ashab al-Yamin al-Islamiya](#), possibly linked to Iran, has made an unsubstantiated claim it carried out the attack. The same group has also claimed responsibility for an [attack on the Finchley Reform Synagogue](#), [threats against the Israeli Embassy in the UK](#) and the [London-based opposition channel Iran International TV](#). The [Met Police](#) and [UK Government](#) have said it is too early to attribute responsibility for the attacks.

For information on Iranian activity in the UK, see the Commons Library briefing, [Iranian state threat activities in the UK](#).

⁸⁹ FCDO, [Lebanon: Joint foreign ministers’ statement](#), 14 April 2026

⁹⁰ HL Deb, [19 March 2026](#), c1060

⁹¹ FCDO, [The United Kingdom is working closely with the Lebanese Government](#), 11 March 2026

⁹² UK Embassy Beirut, [UK announces emergency humanitarian response funding for Lebanon](#), 16 March 2026; FCDO, [UK commits £15 million for vulnerable people](#), 18 March 2026; [UK announces additional £2m humanitarian funding to Lebanon](#), 27 March 2026; [New UK aid for displaced people in Lebanon](#), 16 April 2026

⁹³ British Embassy Beirut, [Vice Admiral Edward Ahlgren ends a two-day visit](#), 25 March 2026

4.3

UK Government: Military actions and bases

Defensive military action

The UK has not participated militarily in the strikes on Iran, but UK aircraft and uncrewed aerial systems (drones) have been deployed in a defensive role to intercept missiles and projectiles, including in [Qatar](#), [Jordan](#), [Iraq](#), and [near UK bases in Cyprus](#).⁹⁴ On 16 March, the Secretary of State for Defence, John Healey, says that UK forces were shooting down drones “almost daily”.⁹⁵

There are [several UK military bases across the region](#), including in Bahrain, the Sovereign Base Areas (SBAs) on Cyprus, and Qatar. Before 2026, the [last attack on the SBAs had been in 1986](#). The [Commons Library briefing on the SBAs](#) provides an introduction to the bases and UK-Cypriot relations.

No UK casualties have been reported.

Additional deployments and support for Gulf allies

The government has made four announcements on military capability being strengthened in the region:

- On 3 March, the government said that forces would be deployed to Cyprus to help counter drones and missiles. These were two Wildcat helicopters and a Type 45 Air Defence Destroyer ([HMS Dragon](#), which arrived in the region on 24 March. [In April it docked for maintenance but remained available for air defence](#)).⁹⁶
- On 5 March, the Prime Minister said four additional jets would be sent to Qatar. The RAF’s Middle East Operational Headquarters is located at Al Udeid Air Base in Qatar, [where a joint typhoon squadron operates](#).⁹⁷
- On 24 March, the government said that lightweight multiple launchers would be deployed to Bahrain, and [Rapid Sentry](#) to Kuwait. These are both types of air defence systems.⁹⁸
- On 31 March, radars, missile launchers and a Royal Artillery battery and battle space managers were to be deployed to Saudi Arabia.⁹⁹

⁹⁴ Prime Minister’s Office, [PM statement on Iran](#), 28 February 2026

⁹⁵ HC Deb, [16 March 2026](#), c611

⁹⁶ Ministry of Defence, [UK sends warship and drone-busting helicopters](#), 3 March 2026; Royal Navy, [Royal Navy destroyer arrives in Eastern Mediterranean](#), 24 March 2026

⁹⁷ Prime Minister’s Office, [PM remarks on the situation in the Middle East](#), 5 March 2026

⁹⁸ HC Deb, [23 March 2026](#), c26

⁹⁹ Ministry of Defence, [Gulf air defences boosted further](#), 31 March 2026

This follows the deployment of radar systems, air defence, and F-35 jets in previous weeks. The Prime Minister said these had followed consultation with the US.¹⁰⁰ Around 1,000 UK troops are now in Cyprus and the Middle East.¹⁰¹

The Foreign Secretary visited Saudi Arabia to meet Gulf leaders on 12 March.¹⁰² In a joint statement with the UK, the GCC “recognized the significant contributions by the UK to the security of the region and expressed appreciation for the recent decision to enhance defensive capabilities in the region”.¹⁰³ UK defence companies have also discussed future Gulf needs.¹⁰⁴

US use of UK bases and legal basis for their use

On 1 March the Prime Minister also said that the US could use UK military bases for a “specific and limited defensive purpose”.

Our partners in the Gulf have asked us to do more to defend them, and it is my duty to protect British lives.

[...] the only way to stop the threat is to destroy the missiles at source – in their storage depots or the launchers which used to fire the missiles.

The United States has requested permission to use British bases for that specific and limited defensive purpose.¹⁰⁵

On 20 March the government said that the US use of bases also includes “US defensive operations to degrade the missile sites and capabilities being used to attack ships in the Strait of Hormuz”.¹⁰⁶ The Prime Minister said this reflected a change in what Iran is striking, rather than a change in UK policy:

We had already said that we will allow the US to strike Iran’s capability to send missiles essentially to land—to infrastructure, hotels, bases. What Friday did was extend that to vessels in the region, because of the illogicality that strikes hit hotels but then you had vessels in the water nearby that needed to be protected under exactly the same legal framework, so actually that was an extension of the original decision.¹⁰⁷

Media reports suggest that the government would not change its position to allow the United States to use UK bases to attack Iran’s civilian infrastructure, [in the event that US strikes had been launched on Iran’s energy infrastructure and bridges on 7/8 April](#).¹⁰⁸

¹⁰⁰ HC Deb, [4 March 2026](#), c803

¹⁰¹ BBC News, [More UK troops to be sent to Middle East, defence secretary announces](#), 31 March 2026

¹⁰² FCDO, [Foreign Secretary touches down in the Gulf](#), 12 March 2026

¹⁰³ Qatar News Agency, [Joint Statement of GCC and UK Foreign Ministers \[...\]](#), 16 March 2026

¹⁰⁴ Ministry of Defence, [UK defence industry steps up support for Gulf partners \[...\]](#), 18 March 2026

¹⁰⁵ Prime Minister’s Office, [PM statement on Iran](#), 1 March 2026

¹⁰⁶ Prime Minister’s Office, [Statement on the conflict in the Middle East](#), 20 March 2026

¹⁰⁷ Liaison Committee, [Oral evidence: The Prime Minister](#), 23 March 2026, Q97

¹⁰⁸ FT, [UK signals it will not let US use British bases to attack Iran’s civilian infrastructure](#), 7 April 2026

The Prime Minister has said that “our bases in Cyprus are not being used by US bombers” because “they are not suitable” for the US.¹⁰⁹

The two bases that the US has access to are Diego Garcia (on the British Indian Ocean Territory/Chagos Archipelago) and RAF Fairford (in Gloucestershire).¹¹⁰ The US uses the bases under operating agreements, described in the [Library briefing on the issue](#). The government says it raises “the need for careful targeting and to ensure that any potential impact on civilians is minimised” with the US.¹¹¹

In March, President Trump said he considered the UK “very uncooperative” on Diego Garcia and that the base should have been made available sooner.¹¹²

The government published legal advice on its decision and RAF operations:

acting in self-defence is the only feasible means to deal with an ongoing armed attack and where the force used is necessary and proportionate. [...] In addition, the UK has responded to a US request which will facilitate specific and limited defensive action against missile facilities in Iran which were involved in launching strikes at regional allies.

The UK’s actions and related support to its allies is solely focussed on ending the threat of air and missile attacks against regional allies.¹¹³

The UK submitted its letter to the UN Security Council on 7 March informing it of actions taken in self-defence under Article 51 of the UN Charter.¹¹⁴

Further reading on international law

- Chatham House, [UK arguments for US operations from its bases blur the line between lawful self-defence and unlawful war on Iran](#), 6 March 2026
- Just Security, [The United Kingdom’s use of force against Iran: Walking a legal tightrope?](#), 5 March 2026
- European Journal of International Law, [The legality of the UK interception of Iranian missiles and permitting a limited US use of British bases](#), 2 March 2026

¹⁰⁹ HC Deb, [2 March 2026](#), c583, 597

¹¹⁰ HC Deb, [17 March 2026](#), c787

¹¹¹ HC Deb, [11 March 2026](#), c356

¹¹² The Independent, [Trump hits out at Starmer over Iran](#), 4 March 2026; Truth Social Donald Trump, [“The United Kingdom, our once great ally”](#), 7 March 2026

¹¹³ Prime Minister’s Office, [Summary of the UK Government legal position](#), 1 March 2026

¹¹⁴ UN Security Council, [Document S/2026/140](#), 7 March 2026

4.4

UK Parliament: Debate and response

Official Opposition view

The Leader of the Opposition, Kemi Badenoch, said she “stand[s] with our allies in the US and Israel” in its operations against Iran.¹¹⁵ She said that the UK should not join the US/Israeli operations but it should take further steps to stop attacks on UK personnel and bases in the region.¹¹⁶

Shadow Foreign Secretary Dame Priti Patel called for the UK to be “much more to be proactive” and criticised the speed of UK defence deployments to the region. She has also said the Iranian ambassador should be expelled.¹¹⁷

The Shadow Attorney General, Baron Wolfson, has argued that “international law ought to provide a mechanism to restrain and, if necessary, end despotic and tyrannical regimes such as that in Iran” and disagreed with the government’s approach.¹¹⁸

Calls to proscribe Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps

MPs have also renewed calls for the government to act against the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), and [quickly bring forward planned legislation on a proscription-like power against the Iranian state organisation](#). In March 2026, the government has said it “taking it forward”.¹¹⁹

Other parties and request for a Commons vote

The Leader of the Liberal Democrats, Sir Ed Davey, opposed the “unilateral and illegal [US] military action” and said “bombs [...] will not bring about the change the Iranian people are crying out for”.¹²⁰ The party has said there should be a parliamentary vote on the US use of UK military bases.¹²¹

The party has also called for King Charles’ visit to the US in April to be cancelled.¹²² The Prime Minister has said that the visit is going ahead to “mark the 250th anniversary of the relationship” between the US and UK.¹²³

¹¹⁵ Kemi Badenoch on Twitter/X, [“I stand with our allies in the US and Israel”](#), 28 February 2026

¹¹⁶ ITN, [Badenoch grilled over party's stance on Iran war](#), 20 March 2026

¹¹⁷ HC Deb, [5 March 2026](#), c982-3 and [BBC Sunday with Laura Kuenssberg, 1 March 2026 transcript](#).

¹¹⁸ Baron Wolfson on Twitter/X, [“I disagree with Lord Hermer KC”](#) and [“6 Against that background, the UK has three \[...\]”](#), 1 March 2026

¹¹⁹ HC Deb, [3 March 2026](#), c723

¹²⁰ Sir Ed Davey on Bluesky, [“The UK can't be dragged”](#), 28 February 2026 and [“Sturmer needs to get on the phone to Trump”](#), 1 March 2026

¹²¹ Sir Ed Davey on Twitter/X, [“No matter how the Prime Minister tries”](#), 1 March 2026; Liberal Democrats, [Sturmer permission for US use of British bases \[...\]](#), 23 March 2026

¹²² BBC News, [Call off King's US visit over Iran, urge Lib Dems](#), 9 March 2026

¹²³ HC Deb, [14 April 2026](#), c555

The use of military force is a prerogative power. See the Commons Library briefing [Military action: Parliament's role](#) for more information on how Parliament can be consulted and informed on the process. The Prime Minister has said that “there is no convention for a vote in relation to defensive action; only offensive action” but also that the Commons “must hold accountability and debate this issue”.¹²⁴

The Leader of Reform UK, Nigel Farage, backed the Israel–US military action and initially said that the UK should allow the US to use its military bases to support the attacks.¹²⁵ He subsequently said that if the UK had been unable to send a destroyer to defend the Sovereign Base Areas on Cyprus, “we certainly don’t have the capability to offer anything, of any value, to the Americans and the Israelis” and should “not be involved in another foreign war”.¹²⁶

On 10 March the Commons Defence Select Committee, following a meeting with Ministry of Defence representatives, said that it had been “satisfied that the UK’s decision making and preparedness measures [before 28 February] [...] were grounded in a coherent logic”, though highlighted concerns for Royal Navy capacity more generally.¹²⁷

The Leader of the SNP and First Minister of Scotland, John Swinney, has called for a diplomatic solution and said “it is for the United States and Israel to now demonstrate how this intervention is compatible” with international law.¹²⁸

The Green Party leader, Zack Polanski, has described the US–Israeli action as “illegal” and said that “the UK must end our cosy relationship with the USA and our ongoing support for Israel”.¹²⁹

¹²⁴ HC Deb, [2 March 2026](#), c592

¹²⁵ The Telegraph, [Farage and Badenoch back Trump \[...\]](#), 28 February 2026

¹²⁶ Sky News on Twitter/X, [“If we can’t even defend Cyprus \[...\]”](#), 10 March 2026

¹²⁷ Defence Select Committee, [Defence Committee statement](#), 10 March 2026

¹²⁸ The National, [Scotland's First Minister issues statement on \[...\] Iran](#), 28 February 2026

¹²⁹ BBC News, [Starmmer speaks to Trump after UK joins defensive operation \[...\]](#), 28 February 2026

Disclaimer

The Commons Library does not intend the information in our research publications and briefings to address the specific circumstances of any particular individual. We have published it to support the work of MPs. You should not rely upon it as legal or professional advice, or as a substitute for it. We do not accept any liability whatsoever for any errors, omissions or misstatements contained herein. You should consult a suitably qualified professional if you require specific advice or information. Read our briefing '[Legal help: where to go and how to pay](#)' for further information about sources of legal advice and help. This information is provided subject to the conditions of the Open Parliament Licence.

Sources and subscriptions for MPs and staff

We try to use sources in our research that everyone can access, but sometimes only information that exists behind a paywall or via a subscription is available. We provide access to many online subscriptions to MPs and parliamentary staff, please contact [hoclibraryonline@parliament.uk](mailto:hoclbraryonline@parliament.uk) or visit commonslibrary.parliament.uk/resources for more information.

Feedback

Every effort is made to ensure that the information contained in these publicly available briefings is correct at the time of publication. Readers should be aware however that briefings are not necessarily updated to reflect subsequent changes.

If you have any comments on our briefings please email papers@parliament.uk. Please note that authors are not always able to engage in discussions with members of the public who express opinions about the content of our research, although we will carefully consider and correct any factual errors.

You can read our feedback and complaints policy and our editorial policy at commonslibrary.parliament.uk. If you have general questions about the work of the House of Commons email hcenquiries@parliament.uk.

The House of Commons Library is a research and information service based in the UK Parliament. Our impartial analysis, statistical research and resources help MPs and their staff scrutinise legislation, develop policy, and support constituents.

Our published material is available to everyone on commonslibrary.parliament.uk.

Get our latest research delivered straight to your inbox. Subscribe at commonslibrary.parliament.uk/subscribe or scan the code below:



 commonslibrary.parliament.uk

 [@commonslibrary](https://twitter.com/commonslibrary)